had cost him dearly. His great-grandfather, Gulab Singh, had been the beneficiary of British indulgence. Prior to admitting him to the privileges of a separate treaty, they elevated him to the status of Maharaja at Amritsar on 15 March 1846, during a state ceremony.[4] It was on this occasion that Gulab Singh stood up, joined his hands in an expression of gratitude to the British and declared himself to be their *zar kharid ghulam* (a bought slave).[5] It was on the next day, 16 March 1846 that the British entered into the Treaty of Amritsar with Gulab Singh, through which he became Maharaja of Jammu and Kashmir.

Contrary to his great-grandfather's tact and guile in dealing with the British, the Maharaja's desire to be independent of British hegemony paved the way for the conditions that led to Sheikh Abdullah's rise to power and for the Maharaja to now be forced to uneasily share power with him. Further, the British not only engineered the operations Gulmarg and Datta Khel to sequester parts of the valley and the entire Gilgit Agency from his rule, but they also planted treacherous British officers in his state forces, who betrayed him at key milestones in his struggle to keep his head above the water.

Further, the Maharaja holding on to the long-standing blood feud between his family and the family of his great-grandfather's brother Raja Dhyan Singh of Poonch, had caused the secession of the areas of Poonch, Mirpur and Muzaffarabad led by Sardar Muhammad Ibrahim Khan, the protégé of Raja Jagat Dev Singh. This was now functioning as Azad Kashmir.

For Maharaja Hari Singh, his world lay in tatters. Little did he know that the unravelling of his state was not going to stop here but was going to continue as his position and power were going to be continually eroded. If he had thought carefully, he might have adopted a different position by willingly aligning himself with his new overlord—the Government of India under Nehru.

It was the consequence of these misjudgments made during these trying times that on that fateful day of 26 October 1947, the Maharaja had signed away what remained of the state that had been welded together by his crafty